

IN POLL GEAR

The Assam assembly poll may still be eight months away, but CM **Himanta Biswa Sarma** is already in full campaign gear, personally overseeing the rollout of welfare schemes and fast-tracking infrastructure projects. A flyover in Guwahati, for instance, was completed in nine months, a record for the state. And it's not just the capital that's seeing action. Sarma has instructed all MLAs to stay put in their constituencies till polls in April next year, barring health emergencies or a direct summons. All this while juggling a full-blown campaign for the Bodoland Territorial Council elections scheduled later this year.

Compliment that Wasn't

When **Prashant Kishor** called the Congress's **Kanhaiya Kumar** a "capable leader", it was more sympathy than endorsement. For, the Jan Suraaj Party chief was hinting that the Congress has all but mothballed Kanhaiya in Bihar, worried he might show up ally RJD's CM face, Tejashwi Yadav. The comment came hours after a viral video showed Kanhaiya being physically blocked from boarding Rahul Gandhi and Tejashwi's truck at a protest against the new voter rolls in Patna on July 9.



THE PEACEMAKER



When the Maran brothers clashed over Sun TV's massive dividend payouts, it was Tamil Nadu CM **M.K. Stalin** who stepped in to broker peace. The uncle (Stalin and the late Murasoli Maran were cousins) persuaded Dayanidhi Maran to withdraw his legal notice against elder brother Kalanithi, bringing the high-stakes feud to a quiet close. Party-watchers say the move echoed the kind of behind-the-scenes diplomacy the CM's father K. Karunanidhi was known for. Stalin's deft handling of the crisis served as a quiet rebuttal to those who feel he doesn't measure up.

Kaushik Deka with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Amitabh Srivastava and Kavitha Muralidharan

SCI-TECH WATCH

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

AN OPEN DATA PROJECT FOR CITY TRAFFIC SOLUTIONS

Believe it or not, Bengaluru, with its public transport woes, has the second largest fleet of city buses in India after Delhi. Every day, 4.6 million commuters (some 30 per cent of the city's population) ride nearly 7,000 buses of the Bangalore Metropolitan Transport Corporation (BMTC). The BMTC aims to increase ridership by another million by next year. Expanding the fleet is one way—1,779 new electric buses will roll out by October. The other, more crucial one, involves data.



HEMANT MISHRA

For the first time, the BMTC, and the Bangalore Metro Rail Corporation Ltd (BMRCL), have published their transport data in a globally recognised open data standard called General Transit Feed Specification. This was part of a start-up challenge that pitted developers to build digital tools for urban mobility using this data. Last week, two city-based mobility apps, Tummoc and Namma Yatri, launched trip planning tools where passengers can access bus/metro schedules and even book rides on autorickshaws on a single platform.

REAL-TIME DATA STACK

BMTC is also working on the Bengaluru Transport Stack, an open data exchange platform that enables sharing of real-time data that could kickstart an innovation ecosystem in mobility solutions. The goal is to integrate different modes of transport and, in the process, increase operational efficiency, reduce travel time and aid traffic management. Ultimately, the plan is to sync mass transport systems and first-and-last-mile connections to make travelling easier for commuters. An 11-month-old project, the stack will have real-time data from public transport providers to micro-mobility services. For India's cities choked by traffic, tech solutions based on open data is the new frontier. ■